

A PCB Test Board for Electrical Characterization of Solder-Bonded Micro-LEDs

Course report — ET4277 + ET4391 — Part 1

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Abstract—We designed a 93 mm × 93 mm two-layer FR-4 PCB to characterize how different solder pastes perform when bonding micro-LEDs. The board carries 26 Würth WL-SFCC 0404 RGB LEDs (8 addressable, 18 in two daisy chains), four 0402 NTCs for forward-voltage thermometry, a 100 Ω 0.1% reference resistor with OPEN/SHORT/LOAD pads for impedance spectroscopy, and a set of TLM ladders and van der Pauw cloverleaves on the same substrate. Putting all of this on one PCB means a single cleanroom session yields bond resistance, contact resistivity, sheet resistance, and junction-to-substrate thermal resistance from the same hardware. No separate test coupons, no inter-board correlation. Two 32-pin headers break every active net out to a breadboard. The board is fab-ready for the Aisler standard pool with ENIG plating; LEDs are deliberately left unassembled, since the bond joint itself is the research subject and has to form under controlled cleanroom conditions. What follows is a walkthrough of the schematic, the characterization methods, the tools needed to run them, and the four-paste comparison the design was built for.

Index Terms—micro-LED, die bonding, solder paste, V_F -TSP, electrochemical impedance spectroscopy, transmission line method, van der Pauw, daisy chain, electrical characterization, PCB test vehicle

I. INTRODUCTION

Mounting a sub-millimeter LED die on a PCB sounds simple until you measure it. The joint has to carry current with a low voltage drop, pull heat out of the die fast enough to keep it from cooking itself, and survive whatever thermomechanical cycling the application throws at it. With SAC305 reflow paste, the cheap default, the quality of that joint depends on paste rheology, stencil aperture, reflow profile, and substrate finish. Alternative chemistries (Au-Sn eutectic [1], Cu-Cu direct bonding [2], polymer-reinforced pastes [3]) trade one of those parameters for another.

This board extends the v1 design Abdelwahab et al. shipped at ECTC 2025 [4]. The v1 measured bond yield and V_F only. v2 adds three more characterization methods (TLM contact resistivity, van der Pauw sheet resistance, EIS impedance) on the

same substrate, so one cleanroom session produces a complete electrical fingerprint of whatever paste-and-reflow combination was run. We deliberately target the Aisler standard pool, not a semiconductor fab, to keep the boards cheap (~40 each) and reproducible at any university lab.

II. BOARD ARCHITECTURE

The board (Fig. 1) is organized top to bottom into five strips. The top edge has the title block and the north 32-pin header. Of the 32 pins, 8 are pre-routed to the chain endpoints and the NTC sense lines; the other 24 are bare for jumpering, which is useful when bypassing the breadboard to probe a test structure directly. Below the header sits the 6×6 DoE bond-pad array at 3.5 mm pitch, with the EIS calibration block in the same horizontal band: bare OPEN/SHORT pads and a 100 Ω 0.1% reference resistor that doubles as the LOAD reference. The middle strip is the test-structure zone: three TLM ladders at $W \in \{0.25, 0.5, 1.0\}$ mm with gaps of 200, 300, 500, 1000, 2000, and 4000 μm , plus four VDP cloverleaves at $W \in \{1.0, 0.5, 0.25, 0.15\}$ mm. The smallest TLM gap stays above the Aisler standard-pool minimum, so the ladders fab in the same run, on the same ENIG surface, as the LED-side traces. The bottom strip carries the eight WL-SFCC LEDs (D1–D8) with the four NTCs interleaved between them, the DCL6 and DCL12 daisy chains (wired through the K_R cathode), and the 32-pin south header that pre-routes every D1–D8 signal out to a ribbon cable.

Design rule budget: 0.20 mm minimum copper track, 0.30 mm minimum copper clearance (1.3× and 2× over the Aisler 0.15 mm spec respectively), 0.30 mm minimum drill, 0.15 mm via annular ring. DRC returns zero violations and zero unconnected items. ENIG plating (Ni 4 μm , Au 0.075 μm) is non-negotiable: every probe pad has to be gold for reliable probe contact, and the customer-bonded LEDs need a gold surface to wet against. Component count: 192 footprints in total, 69 of them assembled by Aisler (4 NTCs, the reference resistor, 64 header pins) and 123 left for the customer (the 26 LEDs bonded in the cleanroom and 97 bare-ENIG test lands).

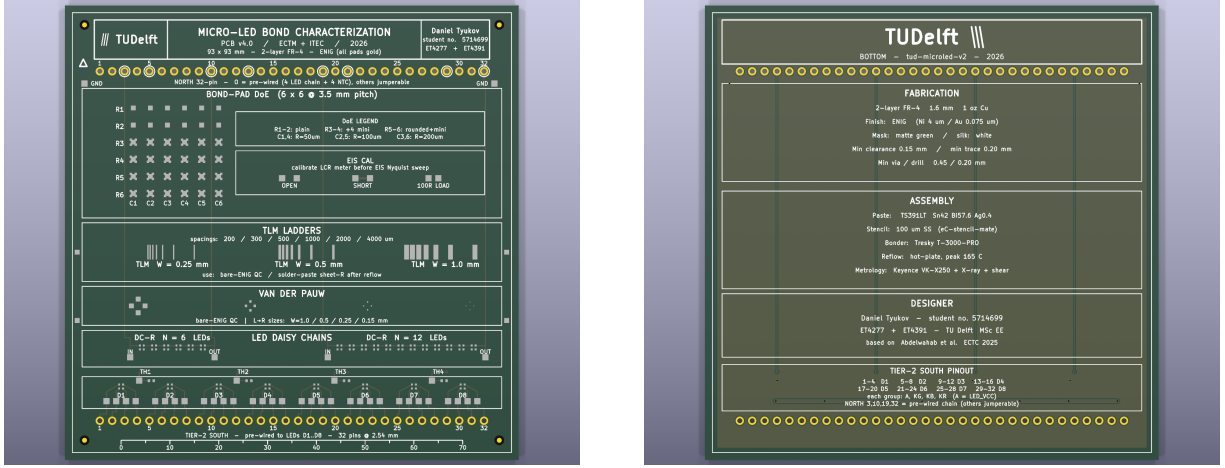


Fig. 1. v4.0.7 PCB, 93 mm $\times$ 93 mm, two-layer FR-4, ENIG finish. Left: top side, with the DoE bond-pad array and EIS calibration block in the upper half, the TLM ladders and VDP cloverleaves in the middle, and the LED row plus NTCs at the bottom. Right: bottom side, with the fabrication / assembly / designer text blocks and the south-header pinout legend that maps the 32 cable wires to the eight LED slots.

The companion KiCad schematic captures the 36 electrically active components (the 26 LEDs, 4 NTCs, the resistor, 3 EIS test points, and the two connectors) and the 164 named nets. The remaining 123 footprints are isolated single-pad test structures; they appear on the PCB and in the BOM but adding them to the schematic would clutter it without information, so they are documented through the on-board silk and the project README instead.

III. CHARACTERIZATION METHODS

A. Forward-voltage thermometry (V_F -TSP)

A diode's forward voltage at a fixed, low sense current falls roughly linearly with junction temperature. The slope, $S \equiv -\partial V_F / \partial T_J$, is constant enough over the operating range to invert for T_J in real time [5]. For a sense current $I_S \ll I_{op}$,

$$T_J(t) = T_{J,0} - \frac{1}{S} [V_F(t) - V_{F,0}], \quad (1)$$

where $V_{F,0}$ is the forward voltage at the calibration temperature $T_{J,0}$. We read V_F across the four bonded contacts of the LED under test via the south header. The substrate reference comes from the four NTCs (TH1-TH4, Murata NCP15XH103J03RC, $R_{25} = 10$ k Ω , $B_{25/85} = 3380$ K [6]) interleaved between the LED pairs and read through the north header. The Steinhart-B equation maps NTC resistance to temperature:

$$\frac{1}{T} = \frac{1}{T_0} + \frac{1}{B} \ln\left(\frac{R}{R_0}\right), \quad (2)$$

with $T_0 = 298.15$ K, $R_0 = 10$ k Ω . We pulse the sense current (100 μ A, 1 ms, 10% duty) to avoid self-heating bias [7]. The bond-joint thermal resistance is then the steady-state ratio of the junction-to-substrate temperature difference to the dissipated power:

$$R_{th,bond} = \lim_{t \rightarrow \infty} \frac{T_J(t) - T_{NTC}(t)}{P_{op}}. \quad (3)$$

B. Electrochemical impedance spectroscopy (EIS)

EIS sweeps a 10 mV AC excitation from 10^{-1} Hz to 10^6 Hz and records the complex impedance $Z(j\omega) = Z' + jZ''$. The Nyquist plot $Z''(Z')$ separates the series bond resistance (the high-frequency intercept, $Z' \rightarrow R_s$ as $\omega \rightarrow \infty$) from the diode's parallel RC dynamics (the low-frequency semicircle). For the standard LED equivalent circuit (R_s in series with $R_p \parallel C_j$),

$$Z(j\omega) = R_s + \frac{R_p}{1 + j\omega R_p C_j}. \quad (4)$$

EIS is only as good as its calibration. The board carries three on-PCB references: EIS_OPEN (two isolated 1.27 mm gold pads, $Z \rightarrow \infty$), EIS_SHORT (paired pads joined by a solder bridge, $Z \rightarrow 0$), and EIS_LOAD (the 100 Ω 0.1% reference resistor, TCR 25 ppm/K [8]). The resistor pads are oversized so they double as four-wire Kelvin probe lands.

C. Transmission line model (TLM)

TLM gives sheet resistance R_{sh} and specific contact resistivity ρ_c from one set of resistance measurements between successive finger pairs at known gaps d [2]. For N identical contacts of width W and characteristic transfer length L_T ,

$$R_{tot}(d) = \frac{R_{sh}}{W} d + 2R_c, \quad R_c = \frac{R_{sh} L_T}{W} \coth\left(\frac{L}{L_T}\right), \quad (5)$$

where L is the contact length. A linear fit of R_{tot} vs d gives R_{sh} from the slope and $2R_c$ from the intercept; ρ_c then follows from $\rho_c = R_c \cdot W \cdot L_T \cdot \tanh(L/L_T)$. The three widths in our ladder set make the transfer length's width dependence directly measurable.

D. Van der Pauw (VDP)

A symmetric cloverleaf gives R_{sh} directly, with no contact-geometry correction, from the implicit relation

$$\exp\left(-\pi \frac{R_A}{R_{sh}}\right) + \exp\left(-\pi \frac{R_B}{R_{sh}}\right) = 1, \quad (6)$$

where R_A and R_B are transverse four-point resistances measured at 90° rotation. For $R_A \approx R_B \equiv R$, this collapses to $R_{sh} = (\pi/\ln 2) R$. The four cloverleaves cross-check the TLM slope and surface any width-dependent edge effects.

E. Daisy-chain bond yield

DCL6 and DCL12 put 6 and 12 LEDs in series through the K_R cathode. One I-V sweep across the endpoints (DCL n _IN/OUT) exercises $2N$ bonds per chain. A bad bond shows up as a discontinuity in $I(V)$ or a chain V_F that overshoots $N \cdot V_{F,nominal}$. For WL-SFCC red at 10 mA, $V_{F,R} \approx 2.05$ V [9], so the DCL12 threshold is roughly 25 V at 10 mA. The K_G and K_B cathodes of every chain LED route to isolated probe pads, so a failure can be localized to a specific die and a specific color rather than blamed on the whole chain.

IV. TOOLING AND WORKFLOW

Software. KiCad 9.0.8. The `.kicad_pcb` is written programmatically by a Python script (`tools/generate_pcb_text.py`) rather than placed through the GUI. Fab outputs come out of `kicad-cli:gerbers` and `drill` (Aisler reads the native `.kicad_pcb` but the bundle ships as a fallback), pick-and-place CSV, top and bottom review PDFs, a 3D STEP model, and the Beagle-format BOM (`tools/gen_aisler_bom.py`).

Fabrication. The board goes to Aisler on the standard 2-layer FR-4 1.55 mm pool with ENIG. Beagle assembly solders the 4 NTCs, the reference resistor, and the 64 header pins (cut from two 1×40 strips). The 26 WL-SFCC LED footprints are marked *do not populate* in the BOM and called out explicitly in the order notes, since the LED bonding is the research subject and has to happen in the TU Delft cleanroom under controlled paste, reflow, and die-bonder conditions. Three boards delivered, fully assembled apart from the LEDs, costs roughly 115–125.

Bonding. LED placement runs on the Tresky T-3000-PRO. Its 95×95 mm work envelope fits the 93×93 mm board with 1 mm of margin per side. Solder paste goes down through a $100 \mu\text{m}$ laser-cut stencil keyed to the WL-SFCC pad layout (four corner pads, each 0.4×0.4 mm at 0.8 mm pitch [9]). Reflow follows IPC J-STD-020E with a peak between 245 and 260 $^\circ\text{C}$, the exact profile depending on the paste vendor’s datasheet.

Measurement. Keithley 2450 SourceMeter for V_F -TSP and DC I-V. Solartron 1260A frequency response analyzer with a 1296A dielectric interface for EIS. HP4156 parameter analyzer for the TLM and VDP fits. T-type thermocouples soldered to the four TC_n gold lands log in-situ reflow temperature, which is useful when a paste lot starts behaving oddly. Probe access is either through 1.27 mm Kelvin tips on the `PP_*` pads or through ribbon-cable breakouts on the 32-pin headers.

V. SOLDER-PASTE COMPARISON

The motivating experiment is a comparison of four commercial solder pastes on identical hardware: same LED part,

same substrate, same reflow profile (within vendor spec), same characterization protocol. The four candidates:

- 1) **SAC305** (Sn 96.5% / Ag 3.0% / Cu 0.5%), the industry baseline.
- 2) **SAC0307**, a low-silver variant. Cheaper, slightly worse on thermal cycling, similar V_F drop.
- 3) **Au-Sn 80/20 eutectic**, the high-temperature reference, with documented best-in-class contact resistivity [1].
- 4) **Polymer-reinforced SAC305**, an impact-tolerant chemistry relevant to flexible-display use [3].

For each paste, a three-board batch (1 trial + 1 real + 1 spare, matching Aisler’s batch size). Per board, measure: chain yield (N_{ok}/N across both DCL6 and DCL12), per-LED V_F at 10 mA, $R_{th,bond}$ from the V_F -TSP transient, R_s , R_p , and C_j from a fit of EIS data to (4), and ρ_c from a fit of TLM data to (5). Cross-board variance is the headline number, since it captures how wide each paste’s process window actually is.

The same hardware supports a few other experiments. The 6×6 DoE bond-pad array (plain, minis, rounded variants) quantifies capillary self-alignment yield against pad geometry. The four TC pads let the reflow profile be measured and iterated against the paste datasheet. The daisy chains, driven with a programmable current source, run accelerated thermo-mechanical fatigue on a known set of bonds.

VI. CONCLUSION

This v2 board puts four characterization methods (V_F -TSP, EIS, TLM, VDP) and a daisy-chain go/no-go test on a single 93×93 mm substrate, so one cleanroom session produces a self-consistent measurement of bond resistance, contact resistivity, sheet resistance, and thermal resistance from the same hardware. The board is fab-ready on the Aisler standard pool with ENIG plating, with the design rules cleared at twice the published manufacturing minima. The schematic, BOM, and tool chain are committed alongside this report so anyone with KiCad and an Aisler account can re-fab a copy. Part 2 will report the first measurement results from the four-paste comparison once the boards land and the cleanroom session is done.

ACKNOWLEDGMENT

This work builds on the v1 board of A. Abdelwahab [4].

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